

An aerial view of a city skyline, likely Melbourne, Australia, with a blue tint. The image shows a dense cluster of skyscrapers and buildings, with a prominent white building in the foreground. The sky is clear and blue.

STATE RELOCATION GUIDE · AUSTRALIA

Victoria

Where you would work, where you would live, and what an ordinary week looks like in Victoria.

Ethicare Resourcing

9 chapters · September 2026

ethicareresourcing.com

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This guide is free, and so is everything in it. Every chapter here is also on the website, where it is kept up to date — so if you are reading this some months after downloading it, check the site for anything that looks time-sensitive. Fees, tax rates and immigration settings change without much notice.

We don't print these. A PDF costs nothing to send and nothing to ship, which felt like the right answer for a company that spends its days moving people around the world.

Welcome to Victoria

Victoria Guide · Chapter 1 of 9



Victoria is the compact state: the smallest mainland footprint holding the second-biggest city, and everything — surf coast, wine valleys, goldfields, high country — within a weekend's reach of Melbourne. For clinicians it offers most of what Sydney does, at housing prices that leave more of the salary alive.

The state that fits in a weekend

Melbourne holds around five million of Victoria's seven — a city of laneways, trams, galleries, and a food and coffee culture that Australians on both sides of the rivalry concede is the country's best. It is a flatter, more grid-like, more European city than Sydney: less harbour theatre, more liveability per dollar.

Beyond it, the state packs remarkable variety into a small map. The Great Ocean Road and the surf coast to the south-west; Geelong and Ballarat and Bendigo — proper regional cities with big hospitals — inland; the Yarra Valley and Mornington Peninsula's vineyards on the doorstep; the Grampians rising from the western plains; and in the east, the high country, where Victoria skis in winter and rides horses through summer.

The clinical picture matches: a large public system with deep tertiary capacity in Melbourne, strong regional health services in cities under ninety minutes away, and genuine rural medicine in the far west and east. The honest costs are a housing market that is expensive by any standard except Sydney's, and a climate famous for delivering four seasons in one day.

Who wrote this

We're a healthcare recruitment company, so we have an interest — but this guide isn't a pitch. There's nothing in it asking you to register, no form, and no visa advice.

Victoria is the state we recommend most often to people torn between city life and the budget. Where we think it's the wrong answer, we say so.

The state, in nine numbers

~7M

People in Australia's second-most-populous state — on its smallest mainland footprint.

~5M

In Greater Melbourne, consistently ranked among the world's most liveable cities.

150+

Public hospitals and campuses across metropolitan and regional health services.

~250 km

The longest drive most Victorians ever need — Melbourne to almost anywhere in the state.

~300,000

In Greater Geelong, the state's second city, an hour down the bay with its own major health service.

4-in-1

Seasons in a day. The forecast is a suggestion; the layered wardrobe is the answer.

250 km

Of tram track in Melbourne — the largest network in the world, and free in the CBD.

UTC+10/11

Same clock as Sydney, daylight saving included. Evening calls to Europe work.

2nd

Gateway. Melbourne's airport flies direct to Asia, the Gulf and beyond — one stop from most of the world.

Six things you only learn once you're here

The weather jokes are documentary

Melbourne can do 35° and a cold front by dinner. Nobody trusts a single-layer plan, and the city's indoor culture — galleries, arcades, food halls — exists because of it.

North or south of the river is a real identity

Northside is warehouse conversions and music venues; southside is beaches and school zones. People commit young and defend it for life. Where you land shapes your Melbourne.

Sport is the civic religion

AFL isn't a pastime here; it's the calendar. Adopting a team — any team — is the single fastest way into workplace small talk.

The regional cities are underrated

Geelong, Ballarat and Bendigo have major health services, commuter trains to Melbourne and family housing that makes city colleagues wince. They are the state's quiet best answer.

Coffee snobbery is load-bearing

The flat white standard is set here. Even hospital cafeterias clear a bar most cities' cafés don't. You will become fussy within a month.

Winter is grey, not cold

Rarely below five degrees, often overcast for weeks. It's London-lite from June to August — and the ski fields being three hours away is the compensation.

A note on Country

Victoria sits on the lands of the Kulin nations around Melbourne and Port Phillip – Wurundjeri and Boonwurrung among them – with Gunditjmara country in the west, Yorta Yorta along the Murray and many others. Victoria is also the state furthest into formal treaty processes with First Peoples.

Acknowledgement of Country opens meetings, and health services work in partnership with Aboriginal community-controlled organisations. Take the cultural induction seriously; it is part of practising here.

How to read this guide

Nine chapters, all of them about Victoria specifically. Anything true of Australia generally – Medicare, visas, Ahpra registration, tax, superannuation, schools – lives once in [Moving to Australia](#) rather than being repeated here.

If you read nothing else, read [Why Victoria](#) for the full case – and what we'd ask you to weigh, and [Where clinicians live](#), because the north-or-south-of-the-river question – and the regional-city question – decide most Victorian lives.

Why Victoria

Victoria Guide · Chapter 2 of 9



The case for Victoria is comparative, and it is strongest when the comparison is Sydney: most of the same clinical depth, most of the same city, meaningfully better housing arithmetic. The case against is the weather and the fact that "cheaper than Sydney" is not the same as cheap.

The arithmetic

Public-sector clinical pay in Australia is set by state awards and agreements, and we don't quote figures until we've verified them against the current instruments. The structural point survives without numbers: Melbourne pay is broadly comparable to Sydney pay, and Melbourne housing runs meaningfully below Sydney housing — the gap is widest exactly where families want to live, in the middle suburbs with good schools and a train line.

That is Victoria's pitch in one sentence: **the second-best job market in the country at a genuine discount on the first.**

The regional multiplier applies here too, compressed by geography. Geelong is an hour from Melbourne, Ballarat and Bendigo about ninety minutes by commuter train — all three run major health services, all three price family houses at a fraction of Melbourne's, and none of them feel like exile, because the city is a day trip.

A typical week

Monday to Friday

Melbourne: 30–50 minutes by train or tram; driving is the losing move. Geelong or Bendigo: 10–20 minutes and a parking spot.

After work

A laneway dinner, a gallery late, bay swimming in summer — or the netball court, because everyone here plays something.

Saturday

Football in winter, cricket in summer, the Queen Vic or a farmers' market in the morning either way.

Sunday

The Yarra Valley or the Mornington Peninsula – wine country forty-five minutes from the city in two directions.

A long weekend

The Great Ocean Road, the Grampians, Daylesford's spa country, or the high country. Nothing is far in Victoria.

Winter

Grey, damp, seven degrees – and three hours from real snow. The trade nobody advertises and locals quietly love.

The six things people ask us

Is there enough work?

Melbourne or Sydney, honestly?

Can I actually buy a house?

How bad is the winter really?

Is it good with children?

How international is it?

When another state fits better

You want winter sun

Victoria has the greyest winters in mainland Australia. Queensland exists for you.

The beach is the point

The bay is swimmable and the surf coast is real, but daily-surf-before-work culture lives in Sydney, Queensland and WA.

You want the cheapest possible start

South Australia and Tasmania undercut Victoria on housing; the regions of NSW and Queensland compete hard.

Big-city friction, again

Melbourne is still a five-million-person city: commutes, competition for rentals, urban noise. If you're leaving that, look regional.

Family is elsewhere

Perth is four hours' flight, Auckland four. Proximity to your people beats every other line in this table.

Where we'd steer you instead

Want the harbour and don't mind paying? **New South Wales**.

Want sunshine and the fastest path to a house? **Queensland**.

Weighing the Tasman? The master's **Australia vs New Zealand** chapter is the place to start.

In our experience

Victoria suits clinicians who want choices inside one registration – tertiary Melbourne, or a regional city where the hospital is serious and the house is half the price. The winters are grey; the case is that everything else isn't.

Victoria at a glance

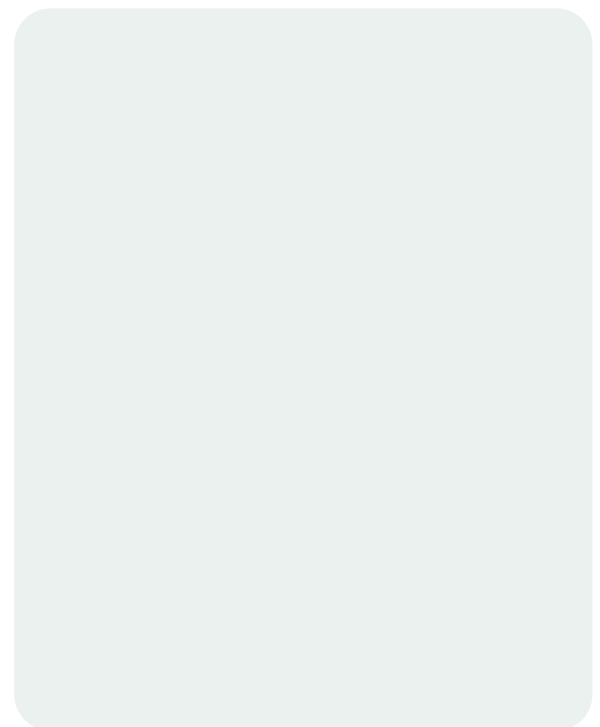
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Victoria compresses a continent's variety into Australia's smallest mainland state: a sheltered bay, a wild surf coast, gold-rush cities on the plains, alpine country that genuinely snows, and the Murray marking the top edge. Nothing is more than a long morning's drive from Melbourne.

The shape of the state

Port Phillip Bay is the anchor: Melbourne wraps its top, Geelong its western shoulder, the Mornington and Bellarine peninsulas its heads. The bay is calm, swimmable and ringed with beach suburbs; the true surf starts beyond the heads, on the **Great Ocean Road** running south-west past Torquay and Bells Beach toward the Twelve Apostles.

Inland and west sit the **goldfields** — Ballarat and Bendigo, Victorian-era cities built on 1850s gold, now regional health hubs — and beyond them the wheat plains and the Grampians' sandstone ranges. North, the state slopes to the **Murray River** and its border towns. East rises the **high country**: Victoria's Alps, with ski villages in winter and cattle-country trails all summer, falling away to Gippsland's lakes and forests in the far south-east.



Where Melbourne sits, with the straight-line distance to Geelong and Bendigo

The Great Ocean Road — the state's signature drive, three hours from Melbourne

The four seasons, in Melbourne

Summer

Dec – Feb

25–30°C

Dry heat, spike days

Autumn

Mar – May

17–23°C

Still, golden, the best

Winter

Jun – Aug

13–15°C

Grey, damp, indoor

Spring

Sep – Nov

17–22°C

Volatile, then lovely

Indicative Melbourne daytime highs. The goldfields run colder in winter with real frosts; Mildura and the north-west run hotter all summer; the Alps do actual snow.

What the numbers don't tell you

Four seasons in a day is logistics, not folklore. A 35-degree northerly can hand over to a 19-degree southerly change within an hour. Melburnians dress in layers, carry the compact umbrella, and check the radar like a vital sign. You will too, quickly.

Summer's heat arrives in spikes. Most of it is pleasant and dry; a handful of days a year run past forty, and those are also the fire-risk days. The warning systems are excellent — download the app, learn your district, and take total-fire-ban days seriously, especially regional.

Winter is an insulation problem. Thirteen degrees outside with single glazing means cold inside. Newer builds and renovated places are fine; charming period terraces are charming and cold. Ask about heating before signing — the master's [Living in Australia](#) covers what to check.

The UV still bites. Grey-sky sunburn is a Victorian speciality. The slip-slop-slap rules apply here as everywhere in Australia, all year.

Where things are, in travel time

Melbourne → Geelong

About an hour by road or V/Line train.

Melbourne → Ballarat / Bendigo

~90 minutes each, both on commuter rail.

Melbourne → Torquay & the surf coast

90 minutes to Bells Beach; the full Great Ocean Road is a weekend.

Melbourne → Yarra Valley / Mornington

45–75 minutes to either wine region.

Melbourne → the ski fields

3–4 hours to Mt Buller, Falls Creek or Hotham in season.

Melbourne → Sydney / Adelaide

90-minute flight or an overnight drive; Adelaide 8 hours by road.

Words you'll hear

The GThe Melbourne Cricket Ground. Capitalised in speech.

FootyAFL. The default meaning of "sport" from March to September.

Northside / southsideThe river divide, and a lifestyle allegiance.

V/LineThe regional trains — the reason Ballarat commutes work.

MykiThe transport card for trams, trains and buses.

The Great Ocean RoadThe surf-coast drive. Doing it slowly is the point.

Spa countryDaylesford and Hepburn Springs — the weekend-away default.

The high countryThe Victorian Alps and their cattle-station valleys.

The short version

A compact state where everything is a weekend: bay, surf, goldfields, wine, snow. The climate is the one honest complaint — grey winters and four-seasons days — and the compact map is the compensation.

[Where clinicians live](#) is next.

Healthcare in Victoria

Victoria Guide · Chapter 4 of 9



Victoria runs the country's second-largest public health system, organised differently from New South Wales in a way that matters when you're job-hunting: not fifteen big districts, but dozens of individual health services, each hiring for itself.

The shape of the system

Victorian public hospitals are run by **independent health services** — metropolitan services covering clusters of Melbourne hospitals, and regional and rural services centred on their towns. Each has its own board, its own recruitment and its own culture. Registration is national through Ahpra; **hiring is service by service**, which means your application strategy here is a list of services, not one portal.

The tertiary depth concentrates in Melbourne — a cluster of major teaching hospitals with the full range of subspecialty, transplant and trauma work, comparable to Sydney's. The regional anchors are substantial: Geelong's health service covers the fastest-growing corridor in the state, and Ballarat, Bendigo, Shepparton and the Latrobe Valley each run major regional hospitals with wide catchments.

Around the hospitals: a large private sector, strong community health — a Victorian tradition; the state pioneered community health centres in Australia — and Aboriginal community-controlled organisations in partnership across the state. How Medicare and the public-private split work is national, and lives once in the master's **How the health system works**.

What the work is like

Tertiary depth without the Sydney queue

Melbourne's teaching hospitals carry equivalent complexity with, in our experience, somewhat less application pressure than the harbour city's most famous addresses.

The west is the growth story

Melbourne's west and the Geelong corridor are growing fastest, with expanding services and constant recruitment — the Victorian mirror of western Sydney.

Community health is a real career here

Victoria's community-health tradition means allied health and nursing careers outside hospitals are better developed than in most states.

Rural west and east

The Wimmera, the Mallee and far Gippsland run genuine rural medicine – broad scope, small teams, real distance. The master's [Regional life](#) is the honest account.

Pay is set by state awards

Each profession has its own instruments, with allowances and salary packaging on top. We quote figures only after verifying them against the current award – see [Pay & conditions](#) for how the system works.

THE REGIONAL HOSPITALS ON A TRAIN LINE

This is Victoria's genuine structural oddity, and it is worth understanding before you rule regional work out: three of the state's major regional hospitals sit in cities with real commuter rail to the capital.

West

The fastest-growing corridor in the state, and the closest thing Australia has to a regional post you can still commute from.

Melbourne

Geelong

Ballarat

North

Major regional hospitals with wide catchments, and goldfields-era cities that carry their own cultural life rather than borrowing Melbourne's.

Melbourne

Bendigo

Shepparton

East

The Latrobe Valley and then genuine rural medicine – broad scope, small teams, and real distance the further out you go.

Melbourne

Traralgon

Far Gippsland

Regional incentives, and a city dinner still possible. Each of these services hires for itself, so your application strategy here is a list of services rather than one portal.

Working with Aboriginal communities

Victorian health services open meetings with Acknowledgement of Country and work in partnership with Aboriginal community-controlled health organisations across the state. Victoria is also the jurisdiction furthest into formal treaty processes, and cultural safety expectations in its health services reflect

that seriousness.

You are not expected to arrive expert. You are expected to take the cultural induction seriously, learn whose Country your service stands on, and treat the partnership as clinical business.

What to ask at interview

Which health service and which campus – and is there cross-campus rotation? Melbourne services span multiple sites.

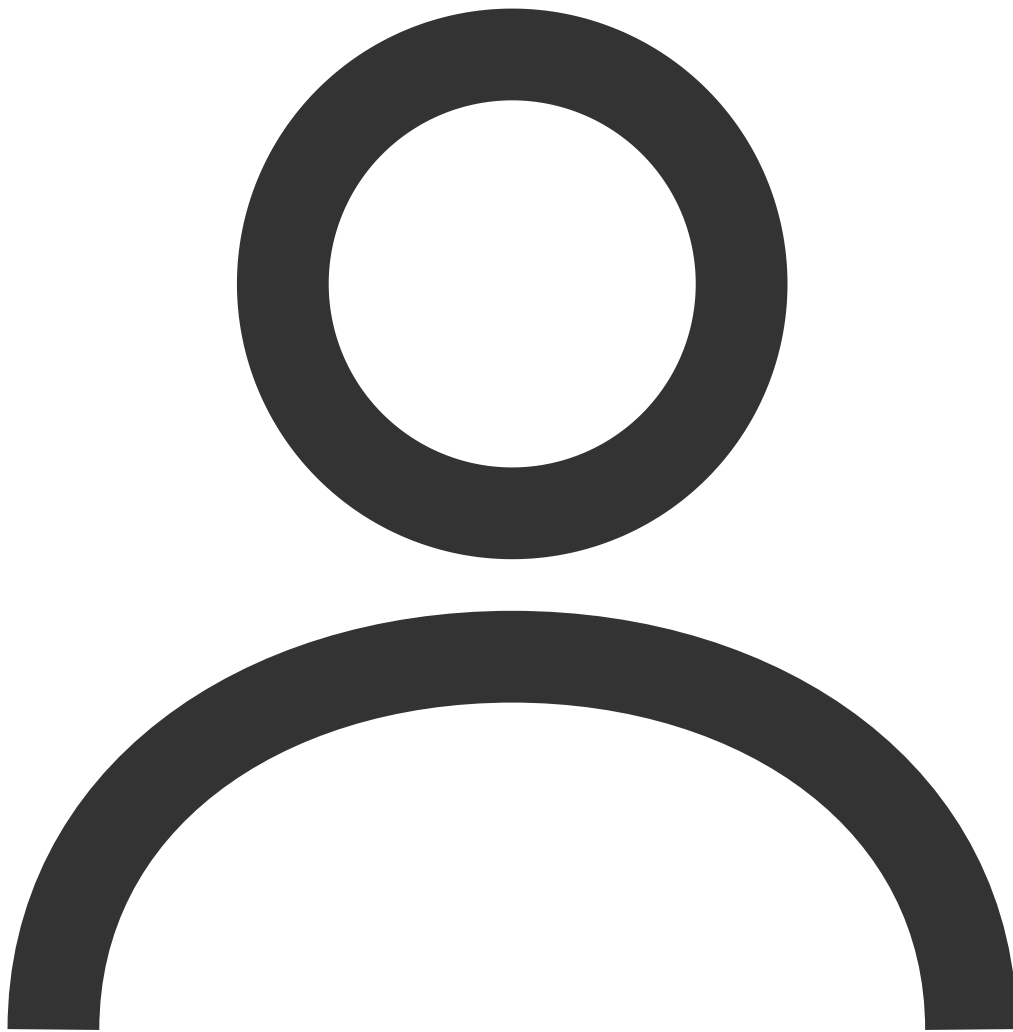
What is the roster pattern, and how are on-call, penalties and allowances handled under the relevant award?

What does salary packaging actually add for this role – verified, not advertised?

For regional roles: what incentives, accommodation or relocation support apply, and for how long?

What supervision, orientation and CPD support exists for clinicians new to Australia?

Where does complex work refer to, and how much of the pathway do I keep?



Sophie

Sophie's insight

Victoria is my quiet recommendation for people who want Sydney's career without Sydney's mortgage. And Ballarat is the sentence I say most often: a major hospital, a beautiful Victorian-era city, a house you can actually buy, and a train to Melbourne when you miss it.

Sophie Careem Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

Before you can start

Ahpra registration, English-language evidence and the visa that goes with your role are national processes, identical in every state. They are explained once, properly, in the master's [Eligibility & registration](#) and [Immigration & visas](#).

Ethicare



What we're recruiting for now, by profession and by state.
Master guide



How awards, allowances and salary packaging work – and what to check before you sign.

Where clinicians live

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Melbourne's first question is the river: north or south. The second is whether you need Melbourne at all — because Victoria's regional cities make the strongest live-regional case in Australia, with commuter trains to prove it.

NORTH OF THE RIVER, OR SOUTH

Melbourne's oldest argument, put to work. The columns share trains, trams and prices — what differs is the texture of a Saturday.

Northside

The culture belt

Gig rooms, galleries and the densest café streets in the country, from Fitzroy out through Brunswick.

Value on the same lines

The middle ring keeps the train and drops the price — the gentrifying edge is visible block by block.

Green out east

The Yarra corridor threads parkland from Ivanhoe to Eltham for the family-scaled version.

Southside

The bay in daily life

Sand, sailing clubs and sea baths from St Kilda around to Mordialloc.

The education spine

The south-east belt concentrates the most chased school zones in Victoria, and charges for them.

The peninsula door

Frankston opens onto weekend coast — longer commute, more house, beach at the end.

And the third answer: no state makes regional living easier to say yes to, commuter trains included — the regional cities get their own section below.

Northside

The inner north

Fitzroy, Brunswick, Northcote, Thornbury – terraces, live music, the best coffee density on earth, and trams everywhere. Couples' territory; family houses at serious prices.

The middle north

Preston, Reservoir, Coburg – the value ring on the same train lines, more mixed and more affordable, gentrifying visibly.

The north-east

Ivanhoe to Eltham along the Yarra – leafy, riverine, family-scaled, with parkland trails into the city.

Southside and the bay

The inner south

South Yarra, Prahran, St Kilda – bayside energy, nightlife and apartments. St Kilda's beach-suburb revival keeps it the international landing pad.

Bayside proper

Brighton to Mordialloc – beach-box postcards, sailing clubs, school zones and prices to match.

The family-by-the-bay dream, costed accordingly.

The south-east spine

Caulfield through Glen Waverley – the school-zone belt, deeply multicultural, on solid train lines. Where education-first families concentrate.

The Mornington side

Frankston and the peninsula approaches – beaches, newer estates and better value, trading commute length for coastline.

Bayside — the postcard, priced like one

Spa country — an hour and a half from the city

The west, honestly

The inner west

Footscray, Yarraville, Seddon — Melbourne's best value inside ten kilometres, Vietnamese and East African food strips, and rising fast.

The growth corridor

Point Cook to Werribee and beyond — new estates, new schools, new hospitals, hot summers. Most house for the money in metropolitan Melbourne, and the region's health services recruit constantly.

The regional cities — Victoria's quiet best answer

Geelong

The second city: a major health service, waterfront revival, the surf coast twenty minutes away, and Melbourne an hour by train. The full compromise-free option.

Ballarat

Gold-boom architecture, a major regional hospital, cool climate, and family houses at a fraction of Melbourne money — on a commuter line. Sophie's most-repeated recommendation.

Bendigo

Ballarat's warmer twin — another gold city with a major hospital, a genuine arts scene, and the same train-line logic.

The surf coast & Bellarine

Torquay, Ocean Grove, Barwon Heads — beach-town living inside Geelong's commute, priced for the privilege but far below bayside Melbourne.

Gippsland & the east

The Latrobe Valley's hospital towns, then lakes and forest to the far east — the state's most affordable family housing, with regional incentives.

The north & the Murray

Shepparton's regional hub, Echuca and the river towns, Mildura in the far north-west — genuine rural medicine, genuine community standing.

Three things to check before you sign

The train line, not the distance. Melbourne liveability is line-shaped: twenty kilometres on a good line beats ten in a tram-less gap. Test the actual timetable at your shift hours.

The school zone, at the exact address. Zone boundaries move Melbourne property prices by six figures — and on a temporary visa, read the master's [School fees on a visa](#) first.

Heating and insulation. Victorian winters are indoor events. Period charm without a working heater is a July mistake; ask before signing — see [Living in Australia](#).

Most clinicians we move rent for six to twelve months first — long enough to pick a side of the river, or to discover that Geelong or Ballarat was the answer all along.

Getting around

Victoria Guide · Chapter 6 of 9



Melbourne is Australia's public-transport city: the world's largest tram network stitched over a radial train system, with regional lines that make Geelong, Ballarat and Bendigo genuine commuter cities. The car matters less here than anywhere else in the country — until you leave town.

Melbourne: trams over the top, trains underneath

The **trams** are the icon and the everyday — 250 kilometres of track, free within the CBD, and the reason inner Melbourne works without a car. The **trains** do the distance: radial lines from the city loop out through every corridor, and the new metro tunnel has added cross-city capacity through the hospital precinct.

Everything runs on **myki** (card or phone), with daily caps. The practical rule from the suburbs chapter bears repeating: Melbourne liveability is line-shaped. Choose the line before the suburb, and test it at your actual shift times — hospital rosters and Sunday-morning frequencies are not natural friends.

Driving, honestly

Two toll roads, not a web

CityLink and EastLink are the paid corridors; most of Melbourne drives free. A tag or pass sorts both — simpler and cheaper than Sydney's toll maze.

Hook turns exist

A handful of CBD intersections make you turn right from the left lane, for the trams' sake. Terrifying once, automatic thereafter.

Trams change the road rules

You stop behind a stopped tram, always — passengers step straight onto the road. The fines and the moral stakes are both high.

Parking is the tax

Inner-city and hospital parking is scarce and priced to discourage. Ask about staff parking at interview; assume nothing.

V/Line: the regional difference

Geelong line

Frequent trains, about an hour – a true commuter service, and the reason surf-coast living with Melbourne work exists.

Ballarat & Bendigo lines

Roughly ninety minutes each, hourly or better – the enabling infrastructure behind the regional-city recommendation this guide keeps making.

Gippsland & the north-east

Traralgon and Seymour–Albury lines serve the eastern hospital towns; less frequent, still workable for flexible rosters.

Fares are capped

Regional fares are capped at metropolitan daily rates – the commute from Ballarat costs no more than one from the outer suburbs.

Flying

Melbourne Airport

Australia's second gateway – direct to Asia, the Gulf, the US and the Pacific. One stop from most of the world, twenty-five minutes from the city by SkyBus (no train yet; it's coming).

Avalon

Geelong's budget airport – domestic low-cost flights, handy if you live west.

The eastern triangle

Melbourne–Sydney is one of the world's busiest air corridors: hourly flights, ninety minutes.

Brisbane a little over two hours.

Getting home

Budget a day each way to Europe or Africa, less to Asia. From regional Victoria, add the V/Line leg rather than a connecting flight.

Distances worth knowing

Journey	Typical time
CBD → Parkville hospital precinct	10 min by tram or metro tunnel
CBD → Box Hill / Footscray / Clayton	25–40 min by train
Melbourne → Geelong	~1 hr, road or V/Line
Melbourne → Ballarat / Bendigo	~90 min by V/Line
Melbourne → Torquay	~90 min by road
Melbourne → Yarra Valley / Daylesford	1–1.5 hr by road
Melbourne → the ski fields	3–4 hr by road, in season
Melbourne → Mildura	~6 hr by road, or a 1-hr flight
Melbourne → Sydney / Adelaide	1.5-hr flight / 8-hr drive

Off-peak estimates. Add for Melbourne roads at commuter hours and for the ski roads on winter weekends.

Licence conversion, buying and registering a car, and the practicalities of Australian driving are national topics, covered once in the master's [Living in Australia](#).

Cost of living

Victoria Guide · Chapter 7 of 9



Victoria's pitch is a discount, so this chapter prices it. Melbourne runs meaningfully below Sydney on housing while matching it on most everything else — and the regional cities cut the housing line in half again.

Why there are no prices on this page

We used to print a weekly rent and a monthly budget table here. We have taken them out. A figure that was true when a page was written is misleading a year later, and a candidate who plans a move around a stale number is worse off than one who plans around none.

What does not go stale is the relationship between places — which suburb, ring or region you choose — and the judgement about which costs catch people out. That is what the rest of this chapter is for. For today's actual numbers use the calculators at the foot of the page, and use them to compare it against the city you are leaving. That is the only comparison that decides anything.

The shape of the money

Clinical pay is set by state awards and is broadly comparable across the eastern capitals; we don't print figures until we've verified them against the current instruments. What changes between cities is the outgoing side, and one line dominates it: rent or mortgage.

The working comparison: **inner Melbourne costs like a serious world city; middle-ring Melbourne costs like Sydney's discount rack; Geelong, Ballarat and Bendigo cost like a different country.** The rest of the budget — groceries, transport, utilities — moves far less between them.

The Victorian twist on utilities: winter heating is a real line here, the reverse of the northern states' air-conditioning summers. Old, draughty period homes are the culprits; newer builds and anything renovated hold heat and money better.

Renting, by ring

Inner Melbourne – north and south

Fitzroy to St Kilda: apartment and terrace territory at the top of the state's range, still a visible step below equivalent Sydney.

Bayside & the school-zone belt

Brighton, the south-east spine – the premium is the zone and the beach; houses priced accordingly.

The middle north and west

Preston, Coburg, Footscray, Yarraville – the value inside ten kilometres, and where most relocating couples land.

The growth corridors

Point Cook, Werribee, Craigieburn, Clyde – the most house for the money in the metro area; commute and summer heat are the trade.

Geelong & the surf coast

A genuine discount on Melbourne, with the coast attached. Torquay carries a lifestyle premium; Geelong proper does not.

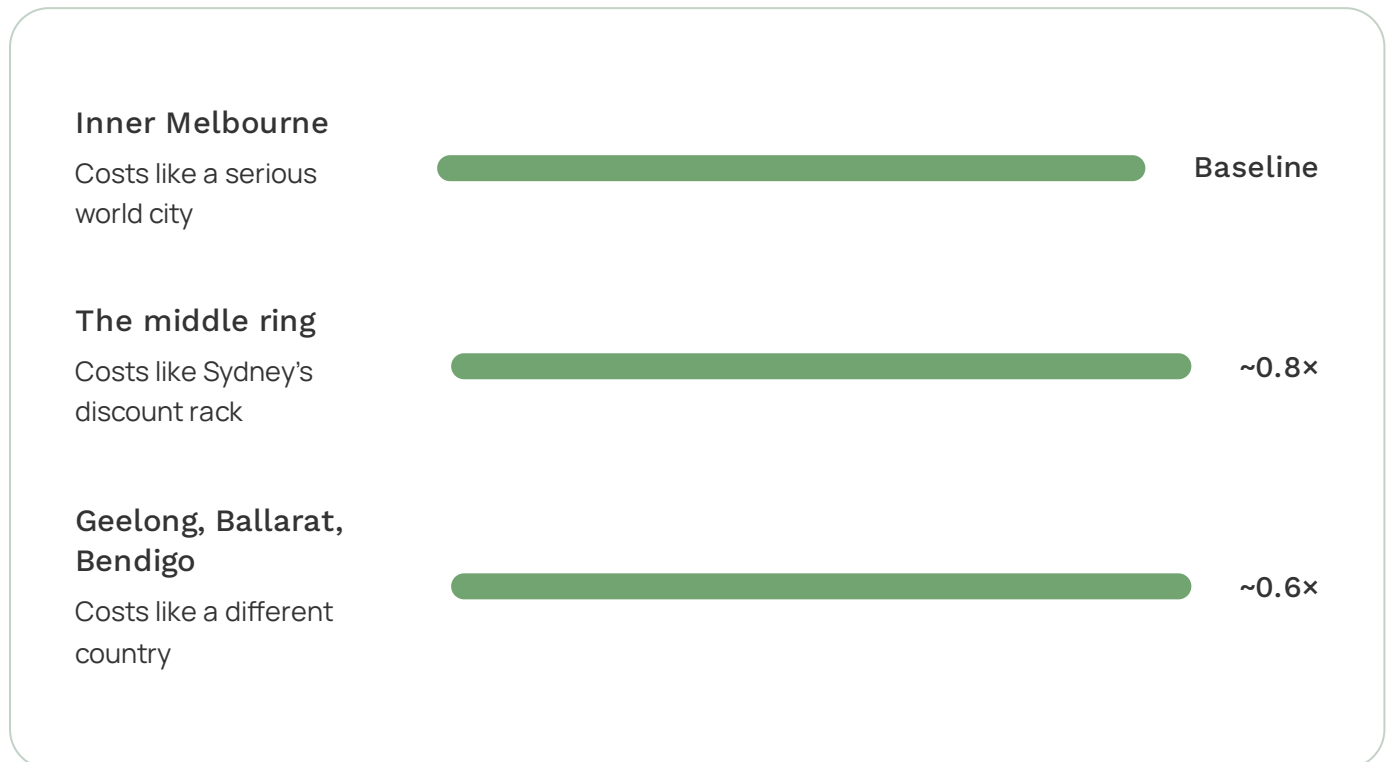
Ballarat, Bendigo & the regions

Family houses at prices that end the conversation – routinely half the metropolitan equivalent, on commuter rail.

THREE RINGS, THREE DIFFERENT COUNTRIES

Monthly rent for the same room or small one-bedroom, at true relative scale.

This is the discount Victoria advertises, priced.



Melbourne runs meaningfully below Sydney on housing while matching it on most everything else. The regional cities cut the housing line in half again – Geelong with the coast attached, and without Torquay's lifestyle premium.

Indicative prices that change over time. Compare the top and bottom rent lines against the NSW guide's – that spread is Victoria's whole argument.

The costs people forget

Winter heating

The Victorian speciality. A draughty terrace can double its energy bill in July; ask about heating and insulation before signing anything.

School fees on a temporary visa

Victoria generally charges nothing: dependants of 482 holders enrol as local students, though school levies and materials still apply. The rule, the exemptions and the other states sit in the master's [School fees on a visa](#).

Health cover for your visa

Many visas require private cover, separate from Medicare – national detail, covered in [Immigration & visas](#).

The eating-out gravity

Melbourne's food scene is priced for two incomes and zero restraint. It is how budgets quietly fail here, and it is worth a named line in yours.

Work out your own numbers

Compare cities

Numbeo · cost of living



Melbourne and Geelong prices against your current city.

(<https://www.numbeo.com/cost-of-living/in/Melbourne>)

Plan your budget



The Australian government's free budgeting tool.

(<https://moneysmart.gov.au/budgeting/budget-planner>)

Property



Live rents and sales — compare inner, middle and regional early.

(<https://www.realestate.com.au/rent/in-vic>)

Master guide



Flights, shipping, bonds and the first ninety days – budgeted once, properly.
Sanity check



A cleaner side-by-side of two cities. Worth running when Numbeo looks off.

(<https://www.expatistan.com/cost-of-living>)

Official data



Slower than the comparison sites, and the one to trust on the direction of travel.

(<https://www.abs.gov.au/statistics/economy/price-indexes-and-inflation>)

The honest summary

Melbourne gives you a serious city at a real discount on Sydney – but it is a discount, not a bargain. The bargain lives ninety minutes up the V/Line: Geelong, Ballarat and Bendigo put clinical pay and Victorian housing back in proportion.

Food, coffee & the everyday

Victoria Guide · Chapter 8 of 9

Melbourne's claim to Australia's best food and coffee is contested only by Sydney, and mostly out of politeness. What makes it matter for a life rather than a holiday is the everyday layer: the food is where the city's communities live, and joining it is how you join Melbourne.

Coffee first, because Melbourne insists

The espresso culture here shaped how the whole country drinks coffee, and the standard is uniform: suburb café, hospital cart or country bakery, the flat white clears a bar most cities' best don't. Cafés are the city's social infrastructure — where prams park, laptops open and colleagues debrief. Learning your local's order is week-one business.

Eating out

The laneways

The CBD's alleys hide bars and dining rooms behind unmarked doors — the famous version of a culture that runs the whole city.

The suburb is the cuisine

Greek in Oakleigh, Vietnamese in Footscray and Richmond, Italian on Lygon, Chinese in Box Hill and Glen Waverley, Middle Eastern in Coburg and Brunswick, Indian in the west. Locals cross town for dinner; you will too.

The pub, Victorian edition

Corner pubs with band rooms and parmas — the northside version — and polished bistros bayside. Either way, the default social venue.

No tipping, honest menus

The price is the price and waitstaff earn a wage. Eating out costs more than UK stickers suggest, and nothing is added at the till.

Markets and what the state grows

The **Queen Victoria Market** is the institution — produce, deli halls and night markets in summer — with South Melbourne and Prahran markets running their own loyal congregations. Every regional city keeps a weekend farmers' market that is genuinely producers-first.

The state behind them: the Yarra Valley and Mornington for cool-climate wine, King Valley for Italian varieties, Gippsland for dairy and beef, the Goulburn for stone fruit, and Victoria's high country for everything a cellar door can host. Wine-country lunch is a forty-five-minute decision from Melbourne, in two directions.

The Yarra Valley — wine country as a Sunday habit, not an occasion

Groceries and the practical stuff

The two big chains plus the discounter anchor every suburb; independent grocers and continental delis carry the depth. Staples price above UK equivalents; market produce is the compensation. Whatever your community eats, a Melbourne suburb sells it — the coverage is arguably the country's best, and it now reaches into Geelong and the bigger regional cities. The master's [Finding your feet & your people](#) maps where communities cluster.

The rhythm of the week

Footy season sets the calendar

March to September, the week bends toward the weekend's fixture. Adopting a team is the fastest social shortcut in the state — any team, chosen for any reason.

Culture is the winter sport

Galleries, theatres, live music — the northside band rooms are legendary — and festivals stacked through the cold months, because Melbourne planned its weather around them.

Saturday sport, Sunday market

Kids' sport in the morning, market or bay walk after — the family weekend has a settled shape that absorbs newcomers quickly.

Long trading hours

Supermarkets late, weekend everything — the convenience layer works the same as the rest of urban Australia.

Honest limitations

Melbourne's food gravity is a budget line. Priced for two incomes, sized for zero restraint.

Regional food scenes are good and improving — but thinner; that is part of the housing discount.

Some imported comforts cost double or don't exist. Every migrant community keeps a list; yours will too.

Coast, country & high country

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Victoria's weekend argument is the compact map: surf coast, two wine regions, spa country, sandstone ranges and genuine ski fields, all within a morning's drive of a five-million-person city. No other Australian capital has this much variety this close.

THE COMPACT STATE, IN DRIVING TIME

Typical driving times from Melbourne, to scale against each other. The marked row is Victoria's quiet rarity: real ski fields inside a morning's drive – the variety no other mainland capital can match.

The Yarra Valley

Vines and balloon mornings,
under an hour from town



~45 min

The surf coast

Torquay and Bells – where
Australian surfing keeps its
head office



~1½ hours

Spa country & Phillip Island

Mineral baths one way, the
penguin parade the other



~1½ hours

The Grampians / Gariwerd

Peaks rising sheer out of
the western plains



~3 hours

The high country

Snow in season, high huts
and cool rivers after the
melt



3–4 hours

Indicative times from the city. The Great Ocean Road is deliberately absent – it is a journey, not a distance, and it gets its own row below.

The coast

The Twelve Apostles at sunset

The Great Ocean Road

Torquay to the Twelve Apostles – Bells Beach, seaside towns, koala forests and the limestone stacks. The state's signature drive, best done slowly with a night in Lorne or Apollo Bay.

The surf coast

Torquay is the surf-industry capital of Australia and ninety minutes from Melbourne – learnable breaks, board hire and nippers culture all along the Bellarine and beyond.

The bay

Calm, swimmable and ringed with beach suburbs – evening swims from November to March without leaving town.

Mornington Peninsula

Hot springs, cellar doors, back-beach walks and bayside villages – the all-season weekend an hour south.

Phillip Island

The penguin parade, surf beaches and the motorcycle circuit – family default, ninety minutes away.

Wilsons Promontory

The mainland's southern tip – granite headlands, white-sand coves and wombats at your tent rope. Book ahead; worth it.

Inland and upward

The Yarra Valley

Cellar doors, long lunches and hot-air balloons, forty-five minutes east. The easiest good weekend in the state.

Spa country

Daylesford and Hepburn Springs – mineral baths, lakes and very good restaurants, ninety minutes north-west.

The Grampians / Gariwerd

Sandstone ranges rising from the western plains – lookouts, rock art and waterfalls, three hours out.

The goldfields

Ballarat's living museum, Bendigo's galleries and Castlemaine's arts scene – Victorian-era streetscapes an easy day trip.

The high country

Real ski fields three to four hours away in season, and the same mountains all summer for trails, huts and river valleys.

The Murray & Gippsland

River-town paddle steamers and beach houses one way; lakes, forests and the far-east wilderness coast the other.

The high country – ski season, then summer trails

Western plains – the resident wildlife commute

Useful links

Tourism



The state's official visitor site – regions, drives and what's on.

(<https://www.visitvictoria.com/>)

Outdoors



Tracks, campgrounds and alerts across the state's parks.

(<https://www.parks.vic.gov.au/>)

The city



Festivals, exhibitions and the city calendar.

(<https://whatson.melbourne.vic.gov.au/>)

Practical



Journey planning, myki and the V/Line timetables worth testing early.

(<https://www.ptv.vic.gov.au/>)

That's the guide

Nine chapters on Victoria. Everything national – Medicare, visas, registration, tax, super, schools – lives once in **Moving to Australia**. When you'd like to talk it through, **we're here** – no pressure, no pipeline.